SKILL.md

Teaching Claude a capability

What We Cover

01 What a SKILL.md is

02 Anatomy of the file

03 A worked example

04 What it costs to load

05 Design principles

What should Claude read?

SKILL.md

Instructions Claude loads on demand.

2,654

Tokens to load

The size of this repo's SKILL.md

01

Anatomy

Where it lives

```
slidekit/
├── SKILL.md
├── src/
│   └── slidekit/
│       └── layout/
├── examples/
└── docs/
```

SKILL.md

```
---
name: slidekit
description: Build .pptx from YAML.
---

## Build loop
1. slidekit build deck.yaml
2. fix the JSON lint errors
```

What the File Carries

A name and a description

When to use it

The workflow to follow

The rules that must hold

What the tool will not do

How Claude Loads It

01 Match

Description fits the task

02 Load

File enters the context

03 Follow

Claude works the steps

Three Jobs of a Skill

Trigger

Say when to use it

Direct

Give the workflow

Constrain

State the hard rules

Sections That Earn Space

Build loop

Four steps

Gallery

30 layouts

Lint codes

Nine codes

Writing the Description

Vague

Helps with slides

A presentation tool

Useful for decks

Triggerable

Builds .pptx from YAML

Names the file types

Says when NOT to use

"Never render to check work."

- slidekit SKILL.md

This Skill in Numbers

2.6k

Tokens

30

Layouts

9

Lint codes

The Build Loop

01

Scaffold

Start valid

02

Author

Edit YAML

03

Build

Run lint

04

Fix

Read JSON

How the Skill Grew

S1	S2	S3	Now
First draft	**Gallery**	**Slide rules**	**One line**
Build loop only	30 layouts	Google Slides	Wrap rule

Errors the Skill Documents

Code	Meaning
E_OVERFLOW	Text exceeds its box
E_WRAP	Text needs two lines
E_MARGIN	Too close to the edge
E_FONT	Font is not metric-safe

With and Without

No skill	With SKILL.md
Guesses the API	Knows the schema
Renders to check	Reads lint JSON
Rediscovers rules	Rules stated once

Cost of One Deck

3.4k

Tokens with the skill

vs

29k

Tokens by screenshot

Measured on This Repo

81

Tokens/slide

YAML

142

Lint payload

JSON

1,844

One screenshot

image

What Good Looks Like

1

Fix round

0

Screenshots

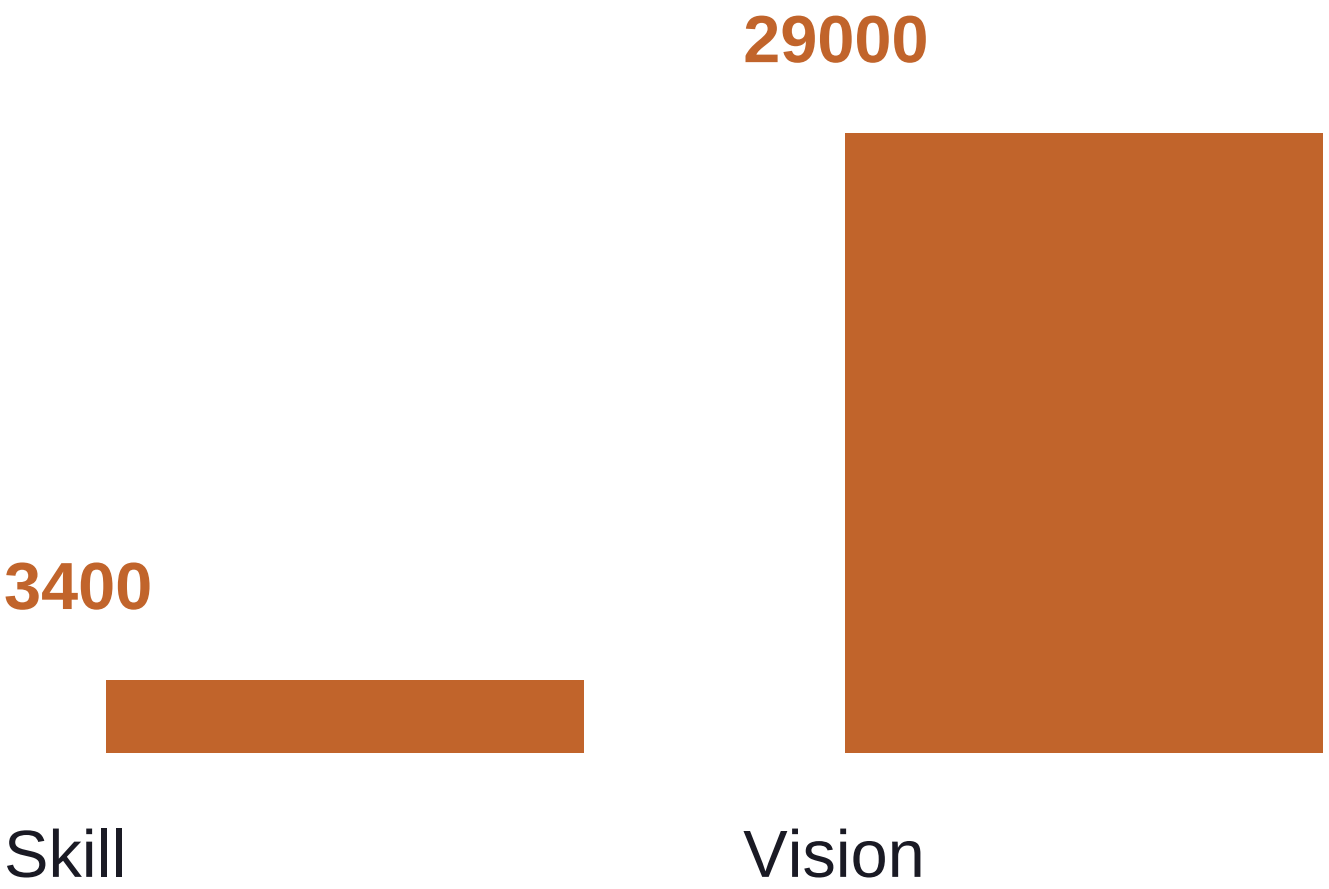
100%

Lint clean

32pt

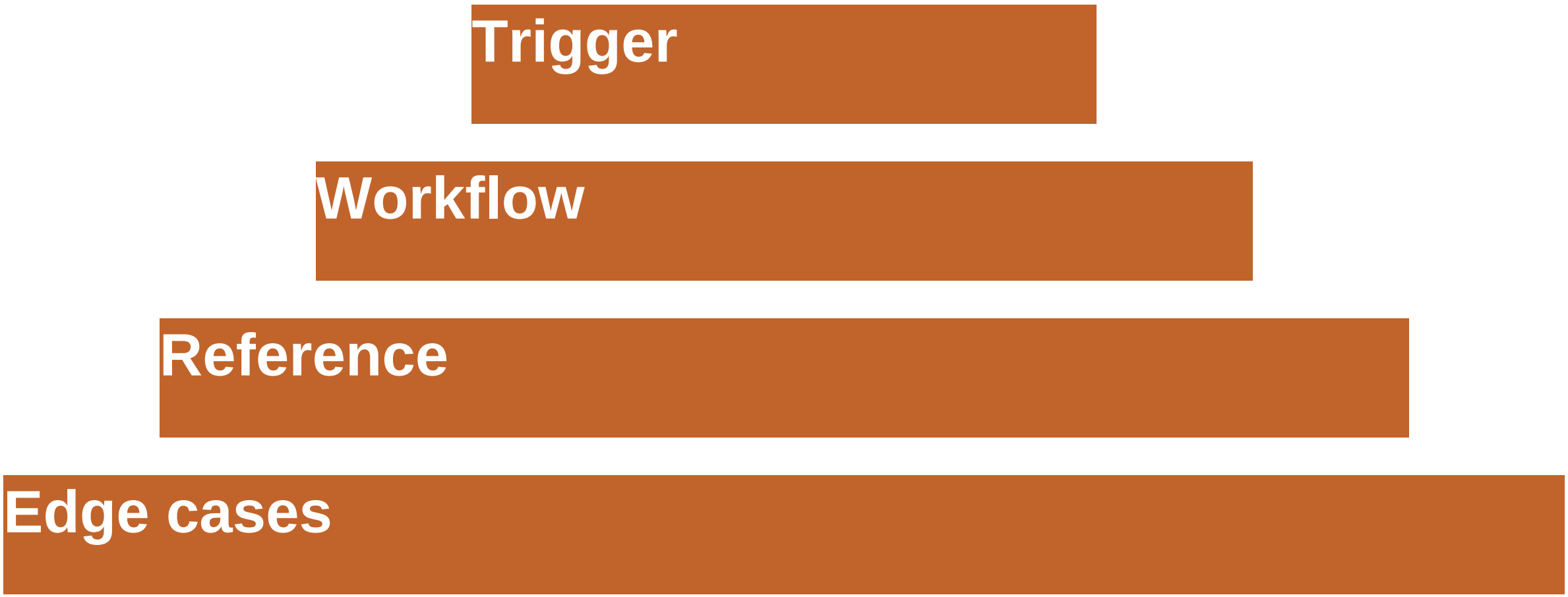
Body floor

Tokens per Deck



Lint beats eyes.

Order of the File



From File to Action

Skills on disk · many

Description matches · one

Loaded · 2.6k

Deck built · 1

What a Skill Wraps

Keeping It Current

Add	Prune	Prove
New layout	Retired layouts	Tests guard it
New lint code	Stale advice	Docs regenerate

Skills as an Approach

Strengths

Rules stated once

Weaknesses

Drifts if unmaintained

Opportunities

Any repeatable workflow

Threats

Too long to load

Ways to Teach a Tool

	SKILL.md	Prompt	Docs only
On demand	**Yes**	No	No
Current	Yes	No	Partly
Cheap	**Yes**	No	Yes

One Rule Above All

Prove fit with math.

Never with a screenshot.